Art and commerce are closely intertwined, so how can artists be truly free and radical? What is the relationship of the artist to the nation-state? How does decolonisation influence cultural practices? What are the modes of artistic dissent? These are some of the animating concerns in *Speech Acts*, a new anthology by the art critic, theorist and curator Geeta Kapur. The collection, featuring essays, talks and interviews, addresses and interrogates themes that Kapur has tackled in her storied career.

"The title, *Speech Acts*, refers to the spoken word and the elocutionary mode; to debates, dilemmas and dialogic exchange," says Kapur over email. "The book rests on my desire to address the *contemporary* through an authorial style that includes contradictions and ironies as well as a sustained poetics in the time of now."

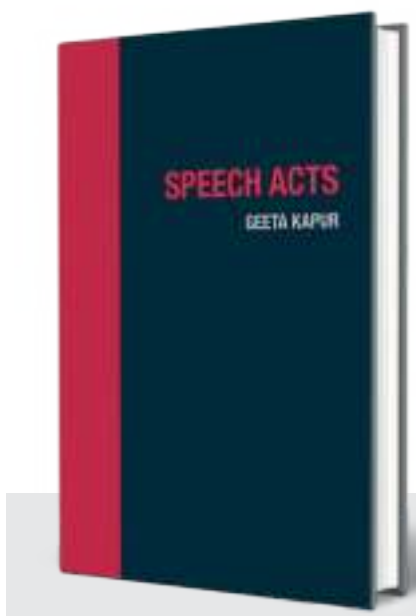
Kapur unpacks the saturated valencies in that one word 'contemporary'. For instance, can it be seen as synonymous with 'modernity'? At a theoretical level, it is, she writes, a "coming together of certain historical forces at a certain moment". As art, the contemporary is showcased in spaces like the biennale or the modern museum. It can take the shape of avant-garde movements and indigenous responses to the existing canon.

A Padma Shri awardee, Delhi-based Kapur is considered one of the definitive thinkers in the fields of art criticism and theory. Her curatorial projects have been featured at the Johannesburg Biennale, NGMA, the Tate Modern and the Royal Academy of Arts in London. She has also served as a jury member at the Venice, Dakar and Sharjah biennales.

Kapur is deeply interested in the revolutionary potential of cultural artefacts, and the politics and economics of art production. "To be realistic, the 'institution of art' will tend to become cautious in a market-driven world; its ideology will be conservative when increasingly faced with an uncontested reign of capital," she says. "Thus, institutional critique as well as alternative ideologies and resistant formations are essential." However, there is in India and elsewhere, "an efflorescence of collective, communitarian, 'marginally' positioned and environmentally grounded groups and practices".

Dissenting artists, she says in an interview, are a construct of 20th-century modernity. "While there are, everywhere, artists who conform or capitulate, a significant number of artists in the world—as also in the Third World and in India—have nurtured a democratic if not also a radical spirit to be played out through their artworks," she says. Kapur notes that dissent is "an a priori condition of art-making today". It could take the shape of outspoken politics or be encoded in terms of style, or vision.

In *Speech Acts*, Kapur does not focus on any single artist or movement as she has previously; the book does not contain a single image. In 'A Cultural Conjuncture in India: Art into Documentary', first presented at a symposium in 2004, she examines the Indian documentary scene: and how filmmakers like Anand Patwardhan and Amar Kanwar engaged and have debated with the nation-state and history. How does she view the emerging crop of internationally feted documentarians from India? "Now... there is a new generation of documentarists who occupy and often opt for marginal spaces and use conspicuously different material, language and form," she says. "This infrastructure of



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